tion of submissions were true deepfakes. Most were low-grade manipulations, not cinematic forgeries. And while Generative AI takes the cost of creation to virtually zero, distribution on social platforms—which require a combination of algorithms, influencers and online crowds to really move content—is still a limiting factor. Inauthentic manipulation often flops because the target audience just doesn't find it compelling.

Labelling is one policy response that many governments are turning to, but it's important to understand the nuanced limitations. Broad rules apply equally to an AI-airbrushed selfie, a whimsical generated image of a unicorn and faked 'photograph' of a politician in a scandalous circumstance that never happened. Label fatigue is real: California, for example, requires businesses to post notices when cancer-causing chemicals are present; the placards are now so ubiquitous that no one pays attention. Uneven compliance can backfire: if synthetic content is sporadically marked, audiences may assume unmarked content is authentic even when it was simply missed. And labels only appear where platforms can attach them—harder in WhatsApp groups and encrypted chats where political content frequently spreads in India. Labelling is a solid transparency measure, but it is not the standalone safeguard people want it to be.

Offering users tools and tiplines to check whether content is authentic will be increasingly important. In India, fact-checking organisations like Alt News and BOOM Live publish debunks. The Misinformation Combat Alliance runs a WhatsApp tipline where citizens can forward suspect content for forensic analysis. International networks like WITNESS's Deepfakes Rapid Response Force connect local journalists to forensic expertise; they helped verify the Tamil Nadu audio clips. These efforts work. But they're under-resourced.

The United States has become a cautionary tale. Institutions that caught coordinated campaigns have been dismantled just as the threat intensifies. Civil society grants have been cut. Major platforms have gutted their trust and safety teams, and election integrity work has become politicised. The *New York Times* recently published an article with the headline 'A.I. Videos Have Flooded Social Media. No One Was Ready'. But the issue isn't that no one knew what needed to be done—it's that the funding and will to address the challenge isn't there.

India has at least started in a place that many democracies have neglected: setting norms. The May 2024 Election Commission advisory urging political parties to refrain from using deepfakes in campaign communications, directing parties to take down deepfake audio or video within hours of becoming aware of it and to warn those responsible is not a silver bullet. But it is important: social media is one thing; social mores are another. In a democracy, political actors have agency. They can decide—publicly—what lines they will not cross, even if the tools exist and the incentives tempt them.

Institutions have to maintain credibility, so that authoritative sources can compete with forwarded rumours. Media literacy that teaches people how Generative AI manipulation works is also critical for an informed democratic society. Indian social scientists and technologists must be funded to study this problem in context. The expertise needs to be local, sustained and independent of Big Tech platforms that serve their self-interest.

Each election cycle brings renewed panic about AI-generated disinformation, followed by relief when democracy doesn't immediately collapse, followed by complacency until the next cycle. We should be able to keep two ideas in our heads at once: deepfakes are not the apocalypse, and they are not 'just noise'. The tools are new, the norms are weak and distrust is high—but the answer isn't panic or dismissal. It's firmly establishing capacity and mores. ■

TAKEAWAYS

- **The problem isn't technology, it is the algorithm-aided polarised environment deepfakes land in**
- **There is also the liar's dividend: if there is a convincing deepfake, real evidence can be dismissed as fake**
- **The solution? Institutional credibility, investing in local tech independent of self-serving Big Tech platforms**

INDIA HAS AT LEAST SET NORMS. A MAY 2024 ELECTION COMMISSION ADVISORY URGED POLITICAL PARTIES TO REFRAIN FROM **USING DEEPFAKES IN CAMPAIGN COMMUNICATIONS**

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